

Architectural debt is the new technical debt

AI makes a clean patch fast. It does not decide **who owns the fact** the patch changes.

A payment status on the order page

The agent adds `paymentStatus` to the orders table.

It copies a value from billing and updates the UI.

Tests pass. The ticket closes.

Who owns the truth when a refund happens?

Two statuses. One payment

Billing records the refund.

Orders still holds the earlier payment status.

A shipping rule reads the orders copy.

Retries, out-of-order events, and partial failures turn a display shortcut into a consistency rule.

Name the owner first

If billing owns payment status, the order page should read a **billing-owned view** or a defined projection.

If orders caches that projection, specify its source, updates, failure behavior, and acceptable staleness.

Orders must not become a second authority.

Change the agent's task

Display billing's payment status on the order page.

Do not add a writable payment field to orders.

Define what the page shows when billing is unavailable.

A contract test can catch violations. It cannot choose the domain owner for you.

Faster code can accumulate debt faster

Local cleanup got cheaper. Cross-service ownership did not.

Before the next small patch, ask:
which part of the system is allowed to say this is true?